

Hackles Club: Orientation for New Club Leaders (90 Minutes)

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

Hackles · a free kit · quillsup.org

© 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials: CC BY-NC 4.0 (free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit). The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]



OCTOBER 2026

© 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials CC BY-NC 4.0. The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]

[Logo: Hackles]

Trust your hackles. *Pause · Check · Tell*

Hackles · a free kit · quillsup.org

Status: DRAFT. [VERIFY] and [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] flags must be cleared before publication.

No names, no data and no recordings collected, ever. Everything in the role-plays is fictional.

01 At a glance

SPECIMEN LABEL	
WHO	New Club leaders and helpers, 4 to 20 people, adults only
TIME	90 minutes, one sitting. Can be split into two 45-minute sessions.
RUN BY	A trainer (an experienced leader or a staff member) and your organisation's safeguarding lead, present or on call for the whole session
NEEDS	Chairs in a circle, the Start Here guide printed for each person, traffic-light cards (green, yellow, red; three per person), fictional role-play cards, pens, a timer
COST	Under \$5 for index cards
RESULT	Every leader can run the First 10 Minutes drill, knows the boundaries, can spot sensitive topics the Club does not cover, and has signed the code of conduct

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
[COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] Your organisation's own screening, training and code of conduct come first. This orientation adds to them and does not replace them.	

LEARNING GOALS

By the end, a leader can:

1. Run a Hackles game from a script.
2. State the two-adult rule, the never-one-on-one rule and the photo rule.
3. Say the "If a child tells you something" steps and practice the First 10 Minutes.
4. Name the topics the Club does not cover and refer a family kindly.
5. Include every child.
6. Say where to find their local reporting rule and their safeguarding lead.

RULES THAT APPLY TO THE WHOLE SESSION

- **Everything is fictional.** Nobody tells a real story.
- **Traffic-light cards.** Green means keep going. Yellow means I need a minute. Red means pause now. Anyone can show any color at any time.
- **Anyone can sit out.** The safeguarding lead is in the room.

- **If a real worry comes up**, the trainer pauses the session, the safeguarding lead steps in, and the person is offered support in private.
- **What is said here stays here**, except what the law requires.

02 Agenda

MIN	PART	TIME
1	Welcome and why	8
2	A Hackles game in 12 minutes	12
3	Safe-adult rules	15
4	The First 10 Minutes drill	25
5	Sensitive topics we do not cover	10
6	Inclusion and boundaries in practice	10
7	Wrap: code of conduct, questions, next steps	10

03 The session

PART 1: WELCOME AND WHY (8 MINUTES)

SAY: "Welcome. You said yes to spending your time with kids, and that matters. In this Club, kids practice noticing when something online feels off, and telling a trusted adult. You do not have to be a technology expert. You do have to be a calm, safe adult. That is the job tonight."

Hook (3 minutes). "Hackles Up?" SAY: "Think of a time something felt odd and you did not know why. A text, a person, a deal. Do not tell it aloud. Notice the feeling. Where in your body was it? Brush a hand up the back of your neck. That is hackles up. It is what we teach kids to notice and act on."

Give the four moves: **Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.** Give the two promises: **A false alarm is fine. It is never your fault.**

Traffic-light check. Show the cards. "Use them any time."

PART 2: A HACKLES GAME IN 12 MINUTES

Run a Quick Catch of Spot the Fishy with the adults as the players.

1. Teach the three answers (FISHY, REAL, PAUSE AND ASK) with hand signals.
2. Read four cards from Set B (B1, B9, B17, B8) in a silly announcer voice. Each takes 2 minutes.
3. After each card the trainer says "Nice noticing!" and the group does the right move.
4. Debrief (2 minutes): "What did that feel like? How would a nine-year-old feel? What would you say to a child who says FISHY on a real card? (A false alarm is fine.)"

Say: "That is a whole session part. Notice how little reading and no devices."

PART 3: SAFE-ADULT RULES (15 MINUTES)

Use the Start Here guide, Section 5. Read the headings aloud, then run a **Scenario Round** (below). Teams of 3. Each team gets one scenario card, one minute to decide, and says what they would do.

Scenario cards (all fictional):

#	SCENARIO	ANSWER
S1	You arrive and the other leader is delayed. Eight children are waiting.	Do not start. Call the safeguarding lead. Move to a public area with other adults, or wait. The two-adult rule holds.
S2	A child wants to tell you something "just you". The other leader is across the room.	Move to a table at the edge of the room, in sight of the other leader. Never behind a closed door.

#	SCENARIO	ANSWER
S3	A parent offers to message you directly about their child.	Use the host organisation's channel. Do not give a personal number.
S4	A child asks to follow you on a personal account.	"That is a no from me, but thank you for asking. I'll see you at Club." Tell your lead.
S5	A parent wants to take photos of the group at the Hackles Day.	"We ask for no photos so every family feels comfortable." Or follow your organisation's policy.
S6	A child hurts themselves slightly at the game.	Use first aid with the other adult present. Write it down. Tell the parent at pickup.
S7	A teen helper (age 15) wants to stay behind with a younger child while the leader gets the car.	Never leave a child with a teen alone. Both adults stay.
S8	A child says, "I told my teacher, but nothing happened."	Thank them. "I am a next rung." Use the Start Here card. Tell your lead.

Say (the three nevers): Never one-on-one. Never promise secrecy. Never share a photo without permission.

[COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] the rules your host organisation sets for screening, ratios, teen helpers and photos.

PART 4: THE FIRST 10 MINUTES DRILL (25 MINUTES)

Counselor or safeguarding lead must be present or on call. Do not run this session in a week when your organisation is dealing with a real crisis without checking with the lead first.

Why pairs. In 25 minutes there is time for two short rounds, so everyone plays the Listener once.

Set-up. Print the "If a child tells you something" card (Start Here, Section 6) for each person. Put the traffic-light cards on every chair. Put the fictional role-play cards (below) in envelopes, one per pair.

Hook demo (3 minutes, trainer and safeguarding lead). Child (the lead): "I think I messed up. I clicked a link and my game account is doing weird things. I think I'm going to be in huge trouble."

- **Wrong (over the top):** "WHAT? Why on earth did you click that?" The child goes quiet.
- **Right (calm):** "Thank you for telling me. You're not in trouble. This happens to smart people. Tell me what happened."

SAY: "That is the only funny one."

The steps (read them aloud):

1. Stay calm.
2. Thank them. "This is not your fault. You are not in trouble."
3. Listen. "Tell me more."

4. Be honest: "I can't keep this a secret, because I need to get you help. I will tell you who I tell."
5. Do not investigate. Do not ask for pictures. Do not contact anyone named.
6. Write down their exact words afterward.
7. Tell your safeguarding lead the same day, or at once if there is danger. Report personally if the law requires it.

Round 1 (6 minutes). Pairs: Teller and Listener. The Teller reads Card 1 and stays in character. The Listener uses the steps. After 4 minutes the Teller says one thing the Listener said that made them want to keep talking. (Teller: if asked for more than the card says, say, "I don't want to say more right now.")

Round 2 (6 minutes). Swap. Use Card 2, 3 or 4.

De-role (2 minutes). Everyone stands. Shake out your hands. Say to your partner: "I'm [name]. That was pretend." One slow breath.

Debrief (5 minutes). Skills only, no stories:

- What phrase do you want to keep?
- What was hardest not to say?
- Where is the line between listening and investigating? (Open prompts only. The people trained to investigate do that.)
- Who do you call? The safeguarding lead says the name and number aloud.

Fictional role-play cards (print one per pair; cut apart).

FIELD NOTE	No. 2
Card 1 (warm-up, calm). You are a 9-year-old. You clicked a link in a game chat and now your game account is doing odd things. You think you will be in trouble. Say: "I think I messed up. I clicked a link and my account is doing weird things." Card 2. You are a 10-year-old. You say: "Somebody sent me a mean message in a game chat. I told my friend and my friend said ignore it. I don't know what to do." (The Listener practices the Next-Rung Rule.) Card 3. You are an 8-year-old. You say: "I'm scared my dad will get really mad if I tell him I tapped on something." (The Listener practices not promising how the parent will react, and offers to be there.) Card 4 (serious; use only with the safeguarding lead present). You are a 12-year-old. You say quietly: "I don't like going home sometimes. Someone there is mean to me and hurts me." (The Listener uses the steps, says the honest limit on secrecy, writes notes after, and tells the lead. Do not role-play any detail beyond this line.)	

Card 5. You are a 13-year-old. You say: "I got a text that said I'd win money. I sent my code to see. Now I'm worried." (The Listener says, "Thank you for telling me. It is not your fault. Let's look at the Oops steps.")

Rule: no card contains anything graphic or sexual. If a real topic like that comes up, see Part 5.

PART 5: SENSITIVE TOPICS WE DO NOT COVER (10 MINUTES)

FIELD NOTE	No. 3
Sensitive-topic rule. Club content stays at the level of the kit's general lessons: scams, passwords, privacy basics, kind behaviour online, telling a trusted adult and the Help Ladder.	

SAY: "The Club does **not** cover sextortion, grooming, trafficking, sexual images, threats or self-harm. Those need trained professionals and a family conversation. We do not teach them, role-play them or answer detailed questions about them. If a child or a parent brings one up, we do four things."

1. **Thank them.** "That is an important question. Thank you for asking."
2. **Say the honest limit.** "It is not one we cover in this Club. The school counselor or a trusted grown-up at home is the right person, and I will help you find them."
3. **Refer.** The school counselor. The resources in the Disclosure and Incident Guide (kit/05_Teacher_Support/). Your safeguarding lead. For families, the Family Engagement Pack page "What to do if your child tells you something scary."
4. **If the question sounds like something that has happened to the child,** use the Start Here card, and tell the safeguarding lead the same day.

Practice (3 minutes, pairs). One plays a parent at pickup who says, "My daughter's friend got a scary message from a stranger. Can you teach the kids about it?" The other practices the four steps. Then swap with this one: a child during a game says, "What do you do if somebody asks you for pictures?" Practice: thank, honest limit, refer, tell the lead. Do not answer in detail.

Say: "You are not a poor leader because you said 'not here'. That is a safe leader."

[COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] how your host organisation handles these topics and who the referral person is. Write the name on your card.

PART 6: INCLUSION AND BOUNDARIES IN PRACTICE (10 MINUTES)

Read each line aloud. The group says what to do.

SITUATION	WHAT TO DO
A child uses a wheelchair and the game is a floor trail.	Tape the trail wide, or use a table-top copy. The child chooses.
A child does not speak English at home.	Show it with hands. Ask a volunteer to translate the take-home card. Never ask another child to translate a hard topic.
A child does not want to join the Hackles Chant.	Let them watch. Nobody is required.
A parent says "we do not do screens at home".	"Great. Everything here is paper."
A child says "my family doesn't have a trusted adult".	"Your Club leaders count today." Tell your lead gently.
A child asks, "Do my parents know what I said?"	Tell the truth. "I will tell the people whose job is to help you. I will tell you who."
A child laughs at another's answer.	"Everyone's answers help the team. Try again kindly."

Boundaries, repeated. No personal contact outside Club channels. No rides. No gifts to individual children. No photos unless permitted. No real passwords, accounts or incidents. Never the villain (an adult voices Gifty).

PART 7: WRAP (10 MINUTES)

- 1. Sign the code of conduct.** [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM: use your organisation's own form.] A model is below.
- 2. Fill in your card.** Safeguarding lead's name and number, local child protection line, emergency number, crisis line.
- 3. Confirm your first session.** Who is the second adult? What is the supply list?
- 4. Q and A.**
- 5. Close.** "Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell." Everyone does the Tell Wave.

Exit slip (anonymous, optional). "One thing I feel ready for. One thing I want more practice with."

04 Model code of conduct for Club leaders

FIELD NOTE

No. 4

[COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] This is a model for discussion. Replace it with your organisation's own code.

As a Hackles Club leader, I will:

1. Always have another screened adult present when I am with children.
2. Never be alone with a child.
3. Treat every child with respect, patience and fairness.
4. Never use physical punishment, shaming or threats.
5. Never promise a child secrecy. I will tell the child who I will tell.
6. Never give a child my personal number, social account or address, and never contact a child directly.
7. Never take or share photos or recordings of children without the host organisation's written permission.
8. Report any concern about a child's safety to my safeguarding lead the same day, and report personally as the law requires: [FILL IN local rule].
9. Never drink alcohol, use illegal drugs or carry a weapon during Club time.
10. Never use a real child's information, a real password or a real incident in any game.
11. Respect every family's values, culture and privacy.
12. Tell my safeguarding lead if I cannot attend or if I have a concern about another adult's behavior.

Signed: _____ Date: _____ Safeguarding lead:

05 Observer checklist (for pair practice)

For each Listener, check what you heard:

- ☐ Stayed calm and kept a soft voice
- ☐ Said "Thank you for telling me"
- ☐ Said "It is not your fault" and "You are not in trouble"
- ☐ Asked an open prompt ("Tell me more")
- ☐ Did not ask "Why did you...?"
- ☐ Was honest about not keeping secrets

- ☐ Did not promise how it will turn out
- ☐ Did not investigate or ask to see images
- ☐ Knew who to call

06 **Trainer prep checklist**

- ☐ Safeguarding lead confirmed present or on call.
- ☐ Start Here guide printed (one per person).
- ☐ Traffic-light cards on chairs.
- ☐ Role-play cards cut and in envelopes.
- ☐ Set B cards ready for the game.
- ☐ Code of conduct copies (your organisation's own).
- ☐ The leader card filled in for the room.
- ☐ A quiet space and a tissue box.